GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Tourism

Discover the Soul of Incredible India

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HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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SHRI GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT

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MESSAGE

Tourism is a powerful driver of economic growth, cultural exchange, employment generation, and regional development. With its unparalleled heritage, diverse landscapes, rich traditions, and vibrant cultural experiences, India possesses immense potential to emerge as one of the world's leading tourism destinations. The Ministry of Tourism plays a pivotal role in unlocking this potential through infrastructure development, destination promotion, sustainable tourism practices, and international engagement.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) recognizes tourism as a catalyst for investment, entrepreneurship, hospitality, infrastructure development, and community-based economic growth. Through policy advocacy, destination development, investment facilitation, industry collaboration, startup promotion, skill development, digital innovation, and international partnerships, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's vision of creating a globally competitive and sustainable tourism ecosystem.

This Knowledge Paper provides comprehensive insights into the Ministry's strategic priorities, tourism policies, flagship initiatives, investment opportunities, and emerging trends across heritage tourism, eco-tourism, wellness tourism, MICE tourism, spiritual tourism, digital tourism platforms, hospitality infrastructure, and destination management. It also identifies collaborative opportunities that can accelerate sustainable tourism growth and strengthen India's global tourism brand.

The publication is intended to serve as a valuable reference for policymakers, tourism professionals, investors, hospitality enterprises, entrepreneurs, technology providers, academic institutions, travel organizations, and development agencies interested in contributing to India's tourism sector. Through knowledge sharing and strategic collaboration, it aims to promote investment, generate employment, enhance visitor experiences, and strengthen regional economies.

As India continues to showcase its unique heritage and cultural richness to the world, tourism will remain an important pillar of inclusive economic development. CCI India remains committed to working alongside the Ministry of Tourism in building a vibrant, sustainable, and globally recognized tourism ecosystem.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
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Preface

Tourism stands at the convergence of economic aspiration and cultural diplomacy. For a nation of India's demographic scale, geographic diversity, and civilisational heritage, the sector is not merely a revenue-generating industry it is a sovereign asset. The Ministry of Tourism, Government of India, functions as the nodal authority responsible for harnessing this asset in service of national development, regional equity, and global positioning.

India received over 9.2 million foreign tourist arrivals in 2023, generating foreign exchange earnings of approximately USD 28.1 billion. Domestic tourism, which is the true backbone of the sector, recorded over 2.5 billion visits in the same year. The sector contributes approximately 5.8 percent to the national GDP and supports an estimated 80 million direct and indirect livelihoods making it one of the largest employment-generating sectors in the country. These are not incidental figures; they represent a structural pillar of the Indian economy that is, by any analytical measure, significantly under-leveraged.

The Ministry of Tourism is therefore engaged in a mandate that extends far beyond hotel registrations and tourist circuit promotion. It encompasses heritage preservation, infrastructure development, digital transformation of travel experiences, rural and community-based tourism, medical and wellness tourism, adventure tourism, MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) facilitation, and India's branding on the global stage. These are complex, multi-stakeholder undertakings that require coordinated ecosystem engagement policy advocacy, investment mobilisation, skilling, startup enablement, and institutional capacity building.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India (CCI India) to present a rigorous, analytically grounded, and strategically structured case for deep collaboration between CCI India and the Ministry of Tourism. The paper is designed for senior decision-makers, including Union Ministers, Secretaries to Government of India, senior bureaucrats, NITI Aayog, investors, development finance institutions, and international multilateral agencies.

CCI India operates as an independent, industry-led body with established networks spanning industry, government, startups, investors, academic institutions, and international chambers. Its role in this collaboration is not that of a passive advocacy organisation it is that of a proactive implementation partner, policy facilitator, and ecosystem builder capable of bridging the gap between government intent and market execution.

The analysis contained in this paper draws upon publicly available government data, Ministry of Tourism reports, NITI Aayog publications, World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) reports, WTTC projections, Reserve Bank of India data, and established consulting frameworks. The interpretations and strategic recommendations herein represent CCI India's independent assessment, developed with the objective of advancing India's tourism ecosystem in alignment with the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Chamber of Commerce and Industry (CCI India)

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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Section 1: Introduction to the Ministry of Tourism

1.1 Ministry Mandate and Constitutional Relevance

The Ministry of Tourism, Government of India, operates under the authority vested in the Union List and the Concurrent List of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution of India. While tourism is a State subject in its operational dimensions with states holding primary responsibility for infrastructure development, destination promotion, and local governance the Central Government exercises its mandate through national-level policy formulation, international tourism promotion, classification and regulation of central tourism assets, and funding support through Centrally Sponsored Schemes. This federal architecture makes the Ministry's role uniquely complex: it must function simultaneously as a policy architect, financial facilitator, brand custodian, and coordination authority across 36 States and Union Territories.

The Ministry's core statutory functions include: formulation of national tourism policy; development and maintenance of tourist infrastructure through the Central Public Works Department and state implementing agencies; regulation and grading of hotels and travel agencies under the Ministry's approved classification system; promotion of India as a tourism destination globally through the India Tourism Offices network spanning 23 international locations; management of the Incredible India brand; and coordination with the Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry of Civil Aviation, Ministry of Railways, and Ministry of Culture recognising that the visitor experience is shaped by multiple ministry domains.

1.2 Institutional Mandate and Strategic Framing

India's National Tourism Policy 2002 which remains the foundational policy document despite being nearly two decades old articulates the positioning of tourism as "a national priority." A new National Tourism Policy framework is under active development, expected to align with the objectives of the Viksit Bharat vision and the NITI Aayog's 2047 roadmap. This policy evolution creates a critical window for structured industry participation, which CCI India is uniquely positioned to support.

The Ministry functions through a network of attached and subordinate offices, autonomous bodies, and public sector undertakings. India Tourism Development Corporation (ITDC), the primary PSU under the Ministry, manages Ashok Hotels and Travellers' Lodges, along with providing event management, catering, and tourism consultancy services. The National Institute of Tourism and Hospitality Management (NITHM) under the Ministry provides research, training, and academic support to the sector's human capital development agenda. The Indian Institute of Tourism and Travel Management (IITTM) with campuses in Gwalior, Bhubaneswar, Nellore, Noida, Cuttack, and Shimla forms the backbone of tourism education and skilling in India.

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1.3 National Significance

Tourism in India is not a luxury sector it is a developmental imperative. The sector serves as one of the most effective mechanisms for rural income generation, given that a significant proportion of tourist circuits pass through semi-urban and rural areas where alternative livelihood sources are limited. Heritage tourism, religious pilgrimage, wildlife tourism, and adventure tourism collectively draw visitors to regions that would otherwise receive minimal economic investment. The Char Dham Yatra alone generates an estimated Rs. 12,000 crore in annual economic activity for Uttarakhand, while the Kumbh Mela at Prayagraj 2019 drew an estimated 240 million visitors and generated economic activity exceeding Rs. 1.2 lakh crore.

India's geographic and cultural diversity from the Himalayas to coastal shores, from the Rann of Kutch to the Northeast's biodiversity corridors positions it as a naturally multi-product tourism destination. The strategic task before the Ministry is to convert this natural endowment into structured, branded, investable tourism products that compete effectively against destinations like Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, the UAE, and European heritage cities. That conversion requires not just government action but sustained industry collaboration, and that is precisely where CCI India's institutional value is most relevant.

Section 2: Historical Timeline of the Ministry of Tourism

2.1 Institutional Evolution

The governance of tourism in India has evolved significantly from its colonial administrative origins to a dedicated, policy-active ministry. Understanding this trajectory reveals where institutional gaps persist and where the next phase of strategic investment must be directed.

Year	Milestone	Strategic Significance
1945	Tourist Traffic Committee	First organized effort to promote inbound tourism under colonial administration; laid groundwork for tourist facilitation infrastructure.
1958	Dept. of Tourism established	Post-independence institutionalisation of tourism governance within the Ministry of Transport; tourism formally recognized as a government function.
1966	ITDC incorporated	India Tourism Development Corporation formed to manage tourism infrastructure, hospitality, and event services as a public sector undertaking.
1982	Independent Ministry created	Tourism elevated to a standalone ministry, signalling its growing economic and strategic importance to the Government of India.
1996	IITTM established	Indian Institute of Tourism and Travel Management created to professionalise human capital in the tourism and hospitality sectors.

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